PADHAKU
First Flight · Class 10 English



CHAPTER 7

Madam Rides the Bus

NCERT Exercise Solutions

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✨ Try each question yourself first, then check the answer. 💡 answers are samples: write your own.

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Madam Rides the Bus · Before You Read – Activity

1 **Look at the words and phrases given below. Then put a tick against the ones you think you will find in the text: a set of passengers, get on the bus, get off the bus, platform, Tickets, please, a roar and a rattle, a row of seats, slowing down to a crawl, blowing a whistle.**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

Likely ticks: **a set of passengers, get on the bus, get off the bus, a roar and a rattle, slowing down to a crawl, blowing a whistle**.

(All of these are actually found in the story. "Platform", "Tickets, please" and "a row of seats" are not used.)

2 **You must have travelled by bus more than once. What can you see from a fast-moving bus? Speak briefly about some of these scenes, or write a sentence or two about them (rivers, green fields, hills, roadside shops, market places, railway tracks, moving trains, vehicles on the road, trees, a crowd, clothes in shops, animals).**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

From a fast-moving bus, **trees** seem to run backwards past the window.

Green fields stretch as far as the eye can see, with cattle grazing in them.

At a **railway crossing** a train rushes past with a loud roar.

In towns, **roadside shops** show bright clothes and a **crowd** of shoppers fills the market place.

Madam Rides the Bus · Oral Comprehension Check (I)

1 **What was Valli's favourite pastime?**

✔ ANSWER

Valli's favourite pastime was **standing in the front doorway of her house** and watching what was happening in the street outside. She had no playmates of her own age.

2 **What was a source of unending joy for Valli? What was her strongest desire?**

✔ ANSWER

The **bus** that travelled between her village and the nearest town, filled each time with a new set of passengers, was a source of unending joy for her.

Her strongest desire was to **ride on that bus, even if just once**.

3 **What did Valli find out about the bus journey? How did she find out these details?**

✔ ANSWER

She found out that the town was **six miles** away, the fare was **thirty paise** one way and the trip took **forty-five minutes**. If she stayed in her seat and paid another thirty paise, she could return on the same bus.

She learnt this by **listening carefully to conversations** between her neighbours and regular bus passengers, and by asking a few **discreet questions**.

4 **What do you think Valli was planning to do?**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

Valli was planning to **take the one-o'clock afternoon bus to town and come back on the same bus** by about two forty-five, secretly, without her mother knowing.

⭐ Madam Rides the Bus · Oral Comprehension Check (II)

1 **Why does the conductor call Valli 'madam'?**

✔ ANSWER

The conductor is a jolly man, fond of joking. Valli behaves like a grown-up: she refuses his help, pays her own fare and talks confidently. So he playfully calls her **'madam'** to tease her.

2 **Why does Valli stand up on the seat? What does she see now?**

✔ ANSWER

A **canvas blind** covered the lower part of her window and cut off her view, so she stood up on the seat.

She saw the **canal**, palm trees, grassland, distant mountains and the blue sky on one side, and a deep ditch and **acres of green fields** on the other.

3 **What does Valli tell the elderly man when he calls her a child?**

✔ ANSWER

She tells him haughtily, **"There's nobody here who's a child. I've paid my thirty paise like everyone else."**

4 **Why didn't Valli want to make friends with the elderly woman?**

✔ ANSWER

Valli found the woman **repulsive**. She had big holes in her ear lobes with ugly earrings, and she was chewing **betel nut** whose juice was about to spill over her lips. She also asked too many questions.

⭐ Madam Rides the Bus · Oral Comprehension Check (III)

1 **How did Valli save up money for her first journey? Was it easy for her?**

✔ ANSWER

She **thriftily saved every stray coin** and resisted the temptation to buy peppermints, toys and balloons, until she had **sixty paise**.

No, it was not easy. At the village fair she had to **stifle a strong desire to ride the merry-go-round**, even though she had the money.

2 **What did Valli see on her way that made her laugh?**

✔ ANSWER

She saw a **young cow, tail high in the air, running fast in the middle of the road** right in front of the bus. The more the driver honked, the faster it ran. Valli laughed till tears came.

3 **Why didn't she get off the bus at the bus station?**

✔ ANSWER

She had planned only to **enjoy the bus ride** and return on the same bus. She was **afraid to go out alone** in town, and she had to be back home before her mother woke up.

4 **Why didn't Valli want to go to the stall and have a drink? What does this tell you about her?**

✔ ANSWER

She said she did not have enough money and refused the conductor's offer of a free drink.

This shows she was **self-respecting** and **independent**: she did not want favours from a stranger. It also shows she was **sensible and careful**.

🤔 Madam Rides the Bus · Thinking about the Text

1 **What was Valli's deepest desire? Find the words and phrases in the story that tell you this.**

✔ ANSWER

Valli's deepest desire was to **ride on the bus** that passed through her street.

Words that tell us this:

- “a tiny wish crept into her head and grew there”
- “she wanted to ride on that bus, even if just once”
- “This wish became stronger and stronger, until it was an **overwhelming desire**”
- “Valli would stare **wistfully** at the people who got on or off the bus”
- “Their faces would kindle in her longings, dreams, and hopes”

2 **How did Valli plan her bus ride? What did she find out about the bus, and how did she save up the fare?**

✔ ANSWER

Information: She listened to neighbours and bus passengers and asked discreet questions. She learnt that the town was six miles away, the fare was thirty paise one way and the trip took forty-five minutes; she could return on the same bus by paying again.

Timing: Her mother napped from about one to four every afternoon. So she planned to take the **one-o’clock bus**, reach town at 1:45 and be back by about 2:45.

Money: She saved every stray coin and gave up peppermints, toys, balloons and even a merry-go-round ride at the fair, until she had **sixty paise** – enough for both ways.

3 **What kind of a person is Valli? To answer this question, pick out the following sentences from the text and fill in the blanks. The words you fill in are the clues to your answer.**

(i) "Stop the bus! Stop the bus!" And a tiny hand was raised _____.

(ii) "Yes, I _____ go to town," said Valli, still standing outside the bus.

(iii) "There's nobody here _____," she said haughtily. "I've paid my thirty paise like everyone else."

(iv) "Never mind," she said, "I can _____. You don't have to help me." "I'm not a child, I tell you," she said, _____.

(v) "You needn't bother about me. I _____," Valli said, turning her face toward the window and staring out.

(vi) Then she turned to the conductor and said, "Well, sir, I hope _____."

✔ ANSWER

(i) **commandingly**

(ii) **simply have to**

(iii) **who's a child**

(iv) **get on by myself**; **irritably**

(v) **can take care of myself**

(vi) **to see you again**

These clues show that Valli is **confident, determined, independent and self-respecting**. She likes to be treated as a grown-up, yet she is also polite and has a good sense of humour.

4 **Why does the conductor refer to Valli as 'madam'?**

✔ ANSWER

The conductor is jolly and fond of joking. Valli insists on getting on by herself, pays her own fare and behaves like an adult, so he humorously calls her **'madam'** – partly teasing her, partly appreciating her grown-up manner.

5 **Find the lines in the text which tell you that Valli was enjoying her ride on the bus.**

✔ ANSWER

- "Valli **devoured everything with her eyes**."
- "Oh, it was **all so wonderful**!"
- "Suddenly Valli **clapped her hands with glee**."
- "She laughed and laughed until there were tears in her eyes."
- "**Struck dumb with wonder**, Valli gaped at everything."

- “Valli wasn’t bored in the slightest and greeted everything with the same excitement she’d felt the first time.”

6 **Why does Valli refuse to look out of the window on her way back?**

✔ ANSWER

On the way back she saw the **young cow lying dead** by the roadside, killed by a fast-moving vehicle – the same cow that had made her laugh. The memory of its lifeless eyes and blood **haunted her** and dampened her enthusiasm, so she no longer wanted to look out.

7 **What does Valli mean when she says, “I was just agreeing with what you said about things happening without our knowledge.”**

✔ ANSWER

Her mother said that many things happen around us that we do not know about, and even when we know, we cannot understand them fully.

Valli agrees because she has just had such an experience: her **secret bus trip** happened without her mother's knowledge, and she saw **death** (the dead cow), which she knew about but could not fully understand. So she speaks from her own new experience.

8 **The author describes the things that Valli sees from an eight-year-old's point of view. Can you find evidence from the text for this statement?**

✔ ANSWER

Yes. The scenes are described with a child's wonder and imagination:

- "the blue, blue sky" and "green, green, green, as far as the eye could see" (simple, repeated words)
- The bus "seemed on the point of **gobbling up** another vehicle"
- "**Trees came running towards them** but then stopped... and simply stood there helpless"
- A running cow seems "very funny" and she laughs till tears come
- "Such big, bright-looking shops! What glittering displays... Such big crowds!"
- She finds the old woman "absolutely repulsive" because of her ear lobes and betel juice.

⭐ **Madam Rides the Bus · Speaking**

1 **This story has a lot of people talking in it. The conductor jokes and laughs with Valli, some passengers try to show their concern for her, and her mother and her aunt spend time chatting. Read the conversations carefully. Then think of similar people, or similar situations that you have experienced. Mimic a person or persons who spoke to you, saying what they said, along with your replies.**

💡 **SAMPLE ANSWER**

Sample role-play (a train journey):

Ticket checker (cheerfully): "Ticket, please, young sir! Travelling all alone to Delhi? Very brave!"

Me: "Yes, sir. Here is my ticket. My uncle will meet me at the station."

Old lady (worried): "Beta, keep your bag close. Do you know your uncle's phone number?"

Me: "Yes, aunty, I have written it in my diary. Thank you."

Ticket checker (laughing): "Then sit back and enjoy the ride, sir!"

(Act it out with the speakers' tone and gestures.)

⭐ Madam Rides the Bus · Writing

1 **Write a page — about three paragraphs — on one of the following topics. 1. Have you ever planned something entirely on your own, without taking grown-ups into your confidence? What did you plan, and how? Did you carry out your plan?**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

My Secret Surprise

Last year I planned my mother's birthday surprise entirely on my own. I did not tell my father or my elder sister, because I wanted it to be my own gift to her.

For two months I saved my pocket money in an old tin box. I bought coloured paper, a small cake and a photo frame. While my mother went to the market, I decorated the room and put our family photo in the frame.

When she came back and saw the room, her eyes filled with happy tears. My plan worked perfectly. I learnt that careful planning and saving can make even a small dream come true.

2 **Have you made a journey that was unforgettable in some way? What made it memorable?**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

A Journey to the Hills

Last summer I travelled with my family from Delhi to Shimla by the toy train from Kalka. It was my first journey to the hills.

The tiny train crawled through more than a hundred tunnels and over old bridges. Pine trees, deep valleys and clouds floating below us made the view magical. At one station we drank hot tea in the cold breeze.

What made it memorable was the slow pace: we could see every little village and waterfall. Even today, when I close my eyes, I can hear the whistle echoing in the mountains.

3 **Are you concerned about traffic and road safety? What are your concerns? How would you make road travel safer and more enjoyable?**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

Safer Roads for All

Yes, I am very concerned. Every day I see people driving too fast, jumping red lights, riding without helmets and using mobile phones while driving. Animals stray on roads, as in Valli's story, and many are killed.

To make roads safer, traffic rules must be strictly enforced and every rider must wear a helmet and seat belt. Speed limits, zebra crossings, footpaths and street lights should be provided, especially near schools. Stray animals should be kept in shelters.

Road-safety lessons should be taught in schools, and we must set an example by following the rules ourselves. Safe roads make travel not only safer but also more enjoyable for everyone.

🤔 The Tale of Custard the Dragon · Thinking about the Poem

1 **Who are the characters in this poem? List them with their pet names.**

✔ ANSWER

Character	Pet name
Belinda (a girl)	—
a little black kitten	**Ink**
a little grey mouse	**Blink**
a little yellow dog	**Mustard**
a little pet dragon	**Custard** (also teased as Percival)
a pirate	—

2 **Why did Custard cry for a nice safe cage? Why is the dragon called "cowardly dragon"?**

✔ ANSWER

Custard was **timid and afraid**, so he wanted the protection of a nice safe cage.

He is called a "cowardly dragon" because, though he looked fierce, he was thought to be a coward and always cried for a safe cage, while the others boasted of being brave.

3 **"Belinda tickled him, she tickled him unmerciful..." Why?**

✔ ANSWER

Belinda tickled Custard mercilessly to **tease and make fun of him** for being a coward who cried for a nice safe cage.

4 **The poet has employed many poetic devices in the poem. For example: "Clashed his tail like iron in a dungeon" — the poetic device here is a simile. Can you, with your partner, list some more such poetic devices used in the poem?**

✔ ANSWER

Simile: "brave as a barrel full of bears"; "sharp as Mustard"; "brave as a tiger in a rage"; "snorting like an engine"; "like a robin at a worm"

Metaphor: “Mouth like a fireplace” is a simile, but “**chimney for a nose**” is a metaphor

Alliteration: “brave as a **b**arrel full of **b**ears”; “**c**latter and a **c**lank”; “**p**istol... **p**irate”

Repetition: “Suddenly, suddenly”; “realio, trulio”

Onomatopoeia: “Weeck!”, “Meowch!”, “ooh!”, “clatter”, “clank”

Hyperbole: “Ink and Blink chased lions down the stairs”; “Belinda giggled till she shook the house”

Coined words / poetic licence: “realio, trulio”, “winda” (for window), “mouseholed”

Refrain: the first two stanzas are repeated at the end.

5 **Read stanza three again to know how the poet describes the appearance of the dragon.**

✔ ANSWER

Custard had **big sharp teeth**, **spikes on top** of his body and **scales underneath**. His **mouth was like a fireplace**, his **nose like a chimney**, and he had **real daggers (sharp claws) on his toes**. He looked very fierce.

6 **Can you find out the rhyme scheme of two or three stanzas of the poem?**

✔ ANSWER

The rhyme scheme is **aabb** (rhyming couplets):

- Stanza 1: house/mouse (aa), wagon/dragon (bb)
- Stanza 2: Ink/Blink (aa), Mustard/Custard (bb)
- Stanza 3: teeth/underneath (aa), nose/toes (bb)

7 **Writers use words to give us a picture or image without actually saying what they mean. Can you trace some images used in the poem?**

✔ ANSWER

- "Mouth like a fireplace, chimney for a nose" – a fire-breathing dragon
- "Pistol in his left hand, pistol in his right, / And he held in his teeth a cutlass bright, / His beard was black, one leg was wood" – a fearsome pirate
- "snorting like an engine... Clashed his tail like irons in a dungeon" – an angry, noisy dragon
- "He went at the pirate like a robin at a worm" – a quick, eager attack
- "Belinda giggled till she shook the house"

8 **Do you find The Tale of Custard the Dragon to be a serious or a light-hearted poem? Give reasons to support your answer.**

✔ ANSWER

It is a **light-hearted, humorous** poem (a parody of a heroic ballad).

- The names Ink, Blink, Mustard and Custard and coined words like “realio, trulio”, “winda”, “mouseholed” are funny.
- The “brave” ones run away while the “cowardly” dragon gobbles the pirate.
- After the fight the others still boast that they would have been braver, and Custard modestly agrees.
- In the end nothing changes: Custard still cries for a nice safe cage.

9 **This poem, in ballad form, tells a story. Have you come across any such modern song or lyric that tells a story? If you know one, tell it to the class. Collect such songs as a project.**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

Example: the song **“Ae Mere Watan Ke Logon”** tells the story of the soldiers who gave their lives in the 1962 war.

Other story-telling songs: “Lakdi ki Kathi” (a child and his wooden horse), Bob Dylan’s “Hurricane”.

Collect such songs, write a short summary of the story each tells, and present them to the class.

⭐ The Tale of Custard the Dragon · Writing (Your Ballad)

1 **Have fun writing your ballad. Gather information (choose/decide an idea/theme), organise your materials under characters and story and then write. Revise and edit your ballad to make it entertaining. Guidelines: purpose – to entertain and interest; decide for whom you are writing; tell a simple narrative, a few major characters, a strong rhythm and rhyme, may have a refrain, divide into verses.**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

The Ballad of Timid Tom

Tom was a cat who was scared of the mice,
He hid in the cupboard and shivered like ice,
And all the house laughed, "What a coward is he!"
But Tom only purred, "Just leave me be."
One night came a thief through the kitchen door,
The dog ran away and hid under the floor,
But Tom gave a yowl and leapt on his head,
The thief dropped his sack and screaming he fled.

Now the dog says, “I’d have caught him, you see,”

And Tom only purrs, “Yes, braver than me!”

And all the house laughs, “What a coward is he!”

But Tom only purrs, “Just leave me be.”

(Simple story, few characters, aabb rhyme, a refrain, divided into verses.)

🎉 **Chapter 7 done! Revise the answers once more tomorrow.**